

Introduction to Social Problems

Sociology 22778

Spring 2026

Tuesdays 11:00am – 12:15pm

Merrill 112

Instructor:	Balikis Gbadamosi	Office: Remote by appointment
E-mail:	bgbadamos@kent.edu	Phone: 234-282-9124 (mobile)
Office Hours:	Wednesday and Thursday 2:00 – 2:30pm	
TA: Faris David		

Why this Class Matters

Every day, you scroll past headlines about rising rents, police shootings, climate disasters, and hospital bills that bankrupt families. You probably have opinions about some of these things. But opinions are not enough anymore. This course will ask more of you than that. It will ask you to slow down, think structurally, and look honestly at the systems that shape who gets ahead and who gets left behind. That is uncomfortable work. It is also some of the most important work you will ever do.

Course Description

In this course we will investigate how social conditions are constructed to be defined as social problems. This course will be divided into two sections. The introduction will be an overview of how sociologists have addressed the study of social problems such as theoretical views (symbolic interactionist, conflict, structural-functionalist and constructionist perspectives), analyze the role of institutions and power structures, and evaluate policies and interventions aimed at solving these problems. Emphasis is placed on critical thinking, evidence-based analysis, and applying sociological perspectives to real-world issues. The second part of the course will make use of the views and theoretical instruments of the former part to examine modern social issues such as race, migration, crime, poverty, mental health, health media and public policy, justice and education. As a class, we will also discuss controversies of various social issues, knowing what to do and how. We shall also discuss the functions of policymakers and social advocates in this part and the media during the definition of social problems.

Learning Objectives

- Provide students with the practical skills and knowledge to understanding social problems.
- Familiarize students with sociological and how these theories explain social problems.
- Distinguish between individual-level explanations and structural/systemic explanations for social inequality and social problems.
- Analyse how race, class, gender, health, and other social categories shape access to resources, power, and opportunity in American society.
- Develop sociological imaginations.
- Communicate sociology analysis clearly in a written or verbal form.

Class Participation

This course runs on active in-class participation, completion of discussion questions, and reflection journals at the end of each class. You are expected to become prepared, engage with the material, and contribute to discussions respectfully. Participation is evaluated on quality over quantity. Listening thoughtfully and building on others' ideas counts just as much as speaking up, coming to class, respecting opinions different than your own, asking for clarification or explanation when you don't understand something.

Discussion post: Please post your discussion post on each chapter to Canvas by their due date. Discussion posts should be in 5 complete sentences with no use of Artificial Intelligence. There is a submission grace period of a day after the due date. Students with no discussion post will be graded as not complete, and for those with a discussion post, there is a 5-point grade on every submission.

Reflection journals: The purpose of this journal is to access students' sociological imagination. The goal is not to have the "right" answer, it is to think sociologically and show your reasoning. Five times throughout the semester, you will submit a short reflection (1–2 pages) connecting that week's topic to a current news story, personal observation, or real-world example. Journals are due in Weeks 3, 5, 7, 10, and 13. Please submit the following reflection journals via Canvas. Assignments are due on the stipulated date on Canvas. Instructions for each assignment can be found on the Canvas and syllabus, as indicated.

Capstone project: For the capstone project student are expected to choose a particular state/community of choice and address one social problem that is currently affecting the community of choice, student is required to make use of resources that will guide their research in depth and present your findings to the class during Week 14. Your presentation should identify the problem, explain it through at least two theoretical lenses, and propose a realistic response or solution.

Guest speaker: In week 12, there will be a guest speaker Kier Gaines, who is a licensed therapist and mental health social media influencer, she will be speaking on mental health and some misconceptions regarding mental health. Kier Gaines will also talk about important actions students can take in taking charge of their mental health.

Class debate: There will be an in-class debate of both the opposing and supporting team, student are encouraged to make research while preparing their points, make sure to support claims with evidence. The graduate assistant will be the judge of the in-class debate. The debate will run for 5 mins so prepare well for this, as points will be deducted for mismanagement of time. The debate topic is: Should the U.S. abolish, defund, or reform the prison system?

Course Policies

Absences: Each student is permitted one “free pass” unexcused absence (no questions asked). Beyond that, absences will impact my assessment of your participation. If you are ill, do not come to class (this is considered an excused absence). Please let Balikis know prior to class if you will be absent.

Accommodations: If you require accommodations associated with a learning difference, or physical/health condition, or caregiving obligations, please let Balikis know, and we will work together to devise a learning plan. You can find below the SAS office location and number.

University Library, 1st Floor, Suite 100
1125 Risan Drive
Kent, OH 44242
Phone: 330-672-3391

ACADEMIC INTEGRITY & PLAGIARISM POLICY

All students are expected to uphold Kent State University's standards of academic honesty. Cheating and plagiarism are serious violations of university policy (Policy 3342-3-01.8) and will not be tolerated in this course.

Plagiarism is defined as presenting the ideas, words, or work of another person or source as your own without proper credit. This includes copying text directly from any source without citation, submitting purchased or borrowed papers, and presenting AI-generated content as your own work.

Cheating includes using unauthorized materials during exams, submitting work previously submitted for another course without instructor permission, and using Generative AI tools (such as ChatGPT) to complete assignments unless explicitly permitted in writing by the instructor.

Consequences for academic dishonesty in this course may include:

- Receiving a zero on the assignment
- Receiving a failing grade (F) for the course
- Referral to the Office of Student Conduct for further disciplinary action, up to and including suspension or dismissal from the university

All confirmed violations will be reported to the Office of Student Conduct via the university's Cheating/Plagiarism Sanction Form. Students have the right to appeal any sanction within 15 class days of receiving written notice. For full details on KSU's policy, visit: www.kent.edu/plagiarism

Use of AI: ChatGPT and other AI generators that use large language models can be useful for researching and writing papers. However, you should be aware of their limitations:

-Errors: AI generators make mistakes. Assume the output is incorrect unless you check the claims with reliable sources.

-Bias: Their output may reflect bias because the data they are trained on already existing information or may not include sufficient data from certain groups.

-Citation: These tools use existing sources without citation. Therefore, using their outputs puts you at risk of plagiarism.

With these limitations in mind, you are welcome to use AI generators to brainstorm and refine ideas, find reliable sources, outline, check grammar, refine wording, and format bibliographies. Beyond bibliographies, you are not allowed to copy and paste material generated by AI and use it in your assignments. **At the end of your bibliography, add a note indicating which AI tool you used and how you used it, including the prompt(s) you used and the date(s). Failure to state use of AI and how it was used results in a 20% deduction of your actual grades.**

COURSE OUTLINE

Note: In the event of a snowy day, we will hold class via remotely via TEAMS

Recommended Reading Text: Social Problems: Continuity and Change by Stevan E. Barkan

Recommended Reading Text 2: Social Problems: A Down-to-Earth Approach by James M. Henslin

Week 1 (1/13): Welcome/ Introduction to Social Problem

Getting to know the instructor, lecture materials, and the syllabus.

Week 2 (1/20): Theoretical Frameworks: Functionalism, Conflict, & Symbolic Interactionism

Week 3 (1/27): The Sociological Imagination: Connecting Personal Troubles to Public Issues

Week 4 (2/3): Poverty and Inequality

Week 5 (2/10): Race and Racism

Week 6 (2/17): Gender

Week 7 (2/24): Crime and Criminal justice system

Class Debate: Should the U.S. abolish, defund, or reform the prison system?

Week 8 (3/3): Mid-term assessment and check-in

Week 9 (3/17): Migration and Immigration

SPRING BREAK-NO CLASS 3/9-3/13

Week 10 (3/24): Education Inequality

Research paper should build up on any social problems you have identified in any city of your choice and discuss with any two sociological theories of choice

Week 11 (3/31): Exam I

Week 12 (4/7): Healthcare and Mental Health

Guest Lecture: Kier Gaines

Week 13 (4/14): Environmental Issues & Environmental Justice

Week 14 (4/21): The Intersections: How Social Problems Overlap

Week 15 (4/28): Review and Social Action

May 5th Final research paper submission

Assignments & Grading

This course uses a points-based grading system. All assignments are designed to push your thinking, connect theory to real life, and build skills you can use.

Assignment Breakdown

Assignment	Points	% of Grade
Reflection Journals (5 × 20 pts)	100	25%
Quizzes (3 × 50 pts)	150	37.5%
Capstone project	100	25%
Class Participation	50	12.5%
Total	400	100%

Grading Scale

Grade	Points	Description
A	4.000	Superior scholarship
A-	3.700	
B+	3.300	
B	3.000	Good performance (undergrad) / Average (grad)
B-	2.700	
C+	2.300	
C	2.000	Fair/Average (undergrad) / Below average (grad)
C-	1.700	
D+	1.300	
D	1.000	Poor but passing (undergrad)
F	0.000	Failure

Assignment Descriptions

Reflection Journals (100 pts)

Five times throughout the semester, you will submit a short reflection (1–2 pages) connecting that week's topic to a current news story, personal observation, or real-world example. The goal is not to have the "right" answer, it is to think sociologically and show your reasoning. Journals are due in Weeks 3, 5, 7, 10, and 13.

Quizzes (150 pts)

Three quizzes will be given throughout the semester to check your understanding of key concepts and theoretical frameworks. The Quizzes are short, multiple choice, matching, true/false, straightforward, and based on class discussions and materials. No surprises, if you show up and engage, you will be prepared. Quizzes fall at Weeks 4, 8, and 12.

Capstone project (100 pts)

At the end of the class, students are required to select a state/community and identify a social problem that community is faced with, explaining it through at least two theoretical lenses and propose a realistic response or solution to that problem. In the course, research it in depth, and present your findings to the class during Week 14.

Class Participation (50 pts)

This course runs on active in-class participation, completion of discussion questions, and reflection journals at the end of each class. You are expected to become prepared, engage with the material, and contribute to discussions respectfully. Participation is evaluated on quality over quantity. Listening thoughtfully and building on others' ideas counts just as much as speaking up, coming to class, respecting opinions different than your own, asking for clarification or explanation when you don't understand something.

I still remember the moment a classmate pulled me aside after a study session and said, “You have a way of making things make sense.” I was not a professor. I had no formal training. I was simply a student who had grown frustrated with being spoon-fed information in a system that rewarded memorization over meaning. Without knowing it, I had already begun teaching, because I had already begun to care. That moment, more than any classroom I have sat in since, is the foundation of my teaching philosophy. I believe that teaching is not simply a profession; it is a duty to humanity, and I intend to carry it that way.

My positionality as a sociologist, and as someone who navigated undergraduate studies in a system not always designed for students like me, shapes every value I bring into the classroom. I did not always have a teacher who saw me as a whole person. I experienced the weight of cognitive load, of coming to class carrying life alongside coursework. These experiences are not incidental to my teaching they are central to it. I enter the classroom as a teacher of the whole student, guided by the belief that empathy, intentionality, and care are not soft additions to good pedagogy. They are the foundation of it. My core belief is simple: everyone can learn, but how you pass on the information matters. Drawing on scholars like Ken Bain, whose work in “What the Best College Teachers Do” challenges educators to think deeply about learning rather than just teaching, and bell hooks, whose writing on love as a classroom practice gave language to what I had always instinctively felt, I have set aside guiding principles for my career in academia. I believe that teaching is an art — beautifully woven, deeply intentional, and something you must fall in love within order to do well. The best teachers are not born; they are continuously becoming.

As a sociologist, I believe this discipline demands a particular kind of teaching, because we practice sociology every single day — in our schools, workplaces, friendships, and in the structures, we so often take for granted. Sociology has an explanation for the social world, and my goal is to help students uncover those explanations naturally. I want them to relearn what they thought they already knew, to see familiar experiences through a structural lens, and to find themselves doing sociology in their everyday interactions

without even realizing it. This is not simply academic exercise, it is a life skill, and it is one of the most powerful things a sociology classroom can offer.

My learning goals are grounded in higher order thinking. I want students to move beyond surface understanding into deep comprehension, critical analysis, and real-world application of sociological concepts. I want them to leave my class with the ability to take their personal experiences and situate them within larger structural forces — to connect the personal to the political, the individual to the institutional. I also want to foster student autonomy, open dialogue, and independent inquiry. A classroom where students feel ownership over their learning is one where genuine intellectual growth happens. I will use fictional literature alongside sociological texts as an entry point into critical thinking, because stories often open doors that theory alone cannot.

The classroom environment I want to create is one built on respect, safety, and co-ownership. I want a space where every student's opinion is valued, where constructive feedback lifts rather than diminishes, and where students and I build class policies together — on technology use, AI, class etiquette, and participation. The tone I want to establish is calming yet encouraging, empathetic yet rigorous. When I speak of love in the classroom, as bell hooks so powerfully frames it, I mean kindness, inclusivity, compassion, and a genuine investment in each student's growth. This will be woven into my materials, my communications, and the way I show up every day.

I also recognize that students arrive carrying lives far bigger than any single course. The resources I make available will go beyond textbooks. I intend to connect students with university mental health services, food assistance programs, and campus wellness activities. I also plan to send weekend email broadcasts, a space for motivational quotes, educational memes, and poetry — that remind students their instructor sees them as whole people. Aside from emotional support, I will invite guest speakers into the classroom to bring lived expertise and diverse perspectives into our conversations, bridging the space between academic theory and real-world experience.

Balakis Gbadamosi teaching philosophies

Assessment in my classroom will reflect my belief that learning is a process, not a performance. Assignments will be grounded in Bloom's Taxonomy, moving students through levels of analysis, evaluation, and synthesis rather than rote recall. Weekly quizzes on assigned readings will keep students consistently engaged with the material. I will incorporate journaling as a reflective practice — a space where students can document what they have learned or relearned and trace how sociology is appearing in their daily lives. Free writing will also be used as a tool to help students access their thinking before it is shaped by the pressure to be right. Together, these methods are designed to measure not just what students know, but how deeply they are thinking.

I am still growing as a teacher — a teacher I dreamed of becoming as a young person navigating a system that did not always make room for me. I acknowledge that my greatest strength is my ability to project life into my teaching, and I intend to grow alongside my students. I am committed to being reflexive in my practice, continuously thinking about what is working, what is not, and what my students are teaching me in return. I want to instill in them self-awareness, critical thinking, and curiosity driven by inquiry-guided questions. I do not walk into the classroom with all the answers. I walk in with intention, empathy, and a genuine commitment to becoming better with every lesson.

My teaching philosophy is not a destination — it is a living document that will grow as I grow, shift as my students teach me, and deepen as I accumulate experience in the classroom. What will remain constant is the belief that first drove me to this path: everyone can learn, but how you pass on the information matters. I intend to honor that belief in every class I teach, every resource I share, and every student I have the privilege of standing before. I am not just teaching sociology. I am teaching people how to see the world differently and that, to me, is everything.

Please complete this template prior to leading your activity workshop in class. Save the document using a file heading that references both your last name and the short title of your activity/exercise (e.g. STACEY ALIENATION EXERCISE). Upload your toolkit into Canvas (in Discussion Board). You may also print out and bring copies of your toolkit to class on the day of your workshop.

TITLE OF ACTIVITY or EXERCISE:

AUTHOR/INSTRUCTOR:

What concept, idea, or theory are you trying to teach?	The looking glass self
What sources did you consult to learn more about teaching this concept, idea, or theory?	Cooley, C.H. (1902). Human Nature and the Social Order. New York: Scribner's Sons. Isaac, A. (2016/2023). "Who Am I?: The Looking Glass Self." TRAILS: Teaching Resources and Innovations Library for Sociology. ASA. Maier, S.L. & Mayer, S.A. (2007). "Teaching Sociological Theory Through Active Learning." Teaching Sociology, 35(3), 227–241. Scheff, T.J. (2005). "Looking-Glass Self: Goffman as Symbolic Interactionist." Symbolic Interaction, 28(2), 147–166. Conrad, P. (1992). "Medicalization and Social Control." Annual Review of Sociology, 18, 209–232. Cardwell, M. (2017). "Teaching Sociology Resources as Classified by Topical Areas." Teaching Sociology.
What are some difficulties in teaching this concept, idea, or theory to students (as identified by the literature or your prior experience)?	I feel like the difficulty I will experience in teaching this learning activity is that it is deeply rooted in theory, and it shows how identity is formed. This may create some level of difficulty when trying to relay the self, and the generalized others to the students.
Is your exercise or activity best suited to online or face-to-face learning? Could it be modified to fit	Yes, my exercise is situated for face-to-face learning and could be modified to fit different instructional models especially with cutting down on the debrief questions.

different instructional modes?	
What materials (if any) do you need for this exercise/activity?	I don't have any materials; the learning activity will be displayed on the projector
How do you carry out the activity or exercise (please provide a list of simple, clear steps)? If need be, attach a separate document for instructions	The activity will be carried out by dividing the class in groups where they will work as a group in answering the debrief questions pertaining to the class activity.
What learning outcomes are associated with this activity or exercise?	The essential learning outcomes are to get student to understand the looking glass self, and how through this process identities are formed, and also this concept matters when looking at marginalized groups.
How will you ensure that learning outcomes are met?	I will ensure these learning outcomes are met by designing my class content that it effectively captures the subject matter, also effectively using the blooms taxonomy to aid how I want to get the student thinking about the course content.
Is there anything else instructors should know before embarking on this activity or exercise?	There nothing else, if there should be it will be communicated before the start of the class.

